



Epson AcuLaser C1100

you 2-years and Epson just 1-year on-site warranty. Not very friendly, is it?

The reason you need to worry about warranty for this category is the recent problems you are bound to face thanks to the heavy load.

Conclusion

There was no mistaking the winner here. It was a complete Epson show. The AcuLaser C1100 beat the rest comprehensively on the performance front. No printer was even near it in terms of the sheer speed and quality of printouts. It had almost all the features you can think of and was also priced very attractively considering the performance. It did lose out slightly in terms of warranty with just 1-year on offer.

It was also the most expensive printer to maintain at Rs 3.12 per page, but it won thanks to sheer performance and a superb price to match it. Without doubt, it was the *Digit* 'Best Buy Gold' in the colour laser category.

MONO LASER MFDs

As with printers, the criteria for categorisation was the duty cycles except that we felt that the Samsung SCX-4720F, despite having a duty cycle of 15,000 pages, deserved to be in the higher performance (workgroup) category, since it is priced at Rs 50,000.

But price notwithstanding, its feature set—duplex printing, networking and additional paper tray—were on par with the MFDs in the higher category, so despite a lower duty cycle, it was placed there.

SOHO MFDs

This category consisted of the MFDs that have a monthly duty cycle of 15,000 pages or lower. There were four MFDs in this category including a Canon, a Lexmark and two from Samsung.

Features

Of all the MFDs, only the Canon MF 3110 could print at a maximum resolution of 1200 x 600 dpi. The rest could not go beyond 600 x 600 dpi. All the MFDs had an input paper tray capacity of 250 sheets. This will be enough for a SoHo set up.

The Samsung SCX-4216F and Lexmark X215 came with an ADF (Automatic Document Feeder),

which is good considering the fact that this category consists of lower-priced MFDs. An ADF is not, strictly speaking, a necessity for a SoHo, but having one sure doesn't hurt!

A higher printer duty cycle is always advantageous, since it is a statement of the reliability and performance of the MFD. Only the Canon MF 3110 had a duty cycle of 15,000 pages, while the other three had a much lesser duty cycle of 10,000. Toner duty cycles were somewhat identical, at 3,200 pages for Lexmark and 3,000 for the rest.

The cost per page of the Lexmark and Canon were neck-and-neck at Rs 1.13 and Rs 1.17 respectively due to the almost identical toner cartridge costs and duty cycles, while the Samsung MFDs had a higher cost per page of Rs 1.67, courtesy their costlier toner cartridges.

The cost per page is calculated as the cost of the toner cartridge divided by its duty cycle.

For the scanner part, the Canon MF 3110 sported the highest optical resolution of 1200 x 2400 dpi, while the others were at 600 x 600. We saw the same thing in the interpolated scan resolution, with Canon bettering the others with 9600 x 9600 dpi, while the others could only manage 4800 x 4800. Note that interpolation is implemented using software and hence, is not as important as the optical resolution.

All scanners in every MFD were flatbeds, and could scan at 24-bit colour depth. All of them had CCD scanning elements, except the Samsung SCX-4100, which has a CIS scanning element. Remember that a CIS scanner produces poorer scans as compared to a CCD scanner. All scanners had the usual functions like scan to e-mail client.

In the copier aspect, too, all scanners had similar features such as standalone copying, reduce or enlarge, and up to 99 copies in multiple-copying mode. Since these were grayscale printers, copying, too, was limited to grayscale. Ninety-nine copies is normally more than enough for a SoHo.

There was also a Fax unit on the Lexmark X215 and the Samsung SCX-4216F, while the Canon MF 3110 and the Samsung SCX-4100 didn't have one.

Features like broadcast faxing and scheduled faxing were available on the X215 and the SCX-4216F. Both these units had 4 MB of Fax memory, which is approximately 320 pages. While a Fax is indeed a good feature, SoHos don't often require



Samsung SCX-4216F